



Leading the way: While seasoned captain Chamari Athapaththu (forefront) remains the face of the Sri Lankan team, the focus this time will be on the youngsters she has long been pushing to the forefront. GETTY IMAGES

The pace group faces an interesting challenge in the Middle East. Surfaces in Dubai and Sharjah are not averse to providing swing and bounce. Pooja Vastrakar and Arundhati Reddy have evolved significantly this season, adding more pace and variations to their game.

Renuka Singh's ability to generate movement with the new ball has been a boon, and she will hope to rediscover her 2022 Commonwealth Games rhythm as India bids for its

maiden senior ICC trophy. While the individual pieces look good, will they all click in place perfectly to complete the jigsaw? Only time will tell.

Not as immovable

Australia, which has won the T20 World Cup a record six times in the eight editions of the tournament, is undoubtedly the biggest obstacle for the Indians. **With the last three titles — 2018, 2020, and 2023 — in the bag and a large part of the core from then still intact in the squad announced for the 2024 chapter, the Aussies are among the favourites to go the distance.**

They will be without the services of ruthless batter and unmatched tactician Meg Lanning, who led Australia to four of its titles. Skipper Alyssa Healy, who has been a part of

the senior core that has carried this team to countless victories, will aim to register one as captain, helping her officially step out of Lanning's very large shadow.

In 12 T20Is this year, the Aussies have come out on top 10 times. Australia hosted New Zealand in a T20I series, predictably sealing it in the second game itself. However, the experience was not without its hiccups. In the second fixture, the Kiwis bundled Australia out for 142 in a batting innings that was every colour of bizarre.

Amelia Kerr's **(facing page, right)** imperious figures of 4/20 proved to be the catalyst. However, Sophie Devine and Co. could not capitalise with the bat, an issue that has consistently pulled the side two steps